

What a Question About the Economy Measures

One economy, one question, and an answer that changes sign every time the White House changes party

84-355 Democracy's Data

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There is one American economy. In any given year it grew or it shrank, and that is true no matter who you ask. A question about the economy is therefore not like a question about abortion or ideology, where people disagreeing *is* the measurement. It looks like a question with a fact sitting behind it.

The American National Election Studies has asked it in every study since 1980. In 2024, 28.3% of Democrats said the national economy had got worse over the past year. Among Republicans it was 82.5%. That is a gap of 54.2 points, on a question about a country both groups live in.

Four years earlier the same question produced a gap of 40.6 points **the other way**.

01 Two questions from one interview

This chapter uses the ANES cumulative file, which the `anes` chapter introduces and the `party-id` chapter takes apart. Two of its columns matter here, and they arrive in the same interview.

Two questions, asked in the same interview, in the codebook's words.

VCF0870 BETTER OR WORSE ECONOMY IN PAST YEAR

Now thinking about the economy in the country as a whole, would you say that over the past year the nation's economy has gotten better, stayed about the same or gotten worse?

1. Better 3. Stayed same 5. Worse

VCF0880 BETTER OR WORSE OFF IN PAST YEAR

We are interested in how people are getting along financially these days. Would you say that you (and your family living here) are better off or worse off financially than you were a year ago?

1. Better Now 2. Same 3. Worse Now

The two do not share a code for 'worse'. One uses 5, the other 3.

Five real rows. VCF0303 is the file's own three-way party column.

```
year VCF0303 party VCF0870 VCF0880
1994 1 Democrat 1 1
1998 3 Republican 1 3
2012 3 Republican 5 3
2020 2 Independent 5 3
2024 1 Democrat 1 2
```

Nothing in either column records who was president when it was asked. That is the fact the two columns turn out to be about.

Read the two code lists again. The first question numbers worse as 5 and the second numbers it as 3. Nothing warns you. Treat the second column the way you treated the first and every worse answer silently disappears.

Party comes from VCF0303, the file's own three-way column. It takes the people who call themselves independent and then admit to leaning, and files them with the party they lean toward. That is a decision rather than a fact, and it is the decision the `party-id` chapter is about. It is the right one here, and the figure two sections down is part of the reason why.

Before you read on, commit to a number. In 2024 a Democratic president was in office. Write down what you think the gap was between Democrats and Republicans on whether the *national economy* had got worse – and then write down what you think it was on whether **their own household finances** had got worse. You will see both.

02 The sign follows the president

Here is the subtraction for every study from 1980 to 2024: the share of Democrats who said worse, minus the share of Republicans, in percentage points. The bands behind the bars are the party of the president in office when the interviews were done.

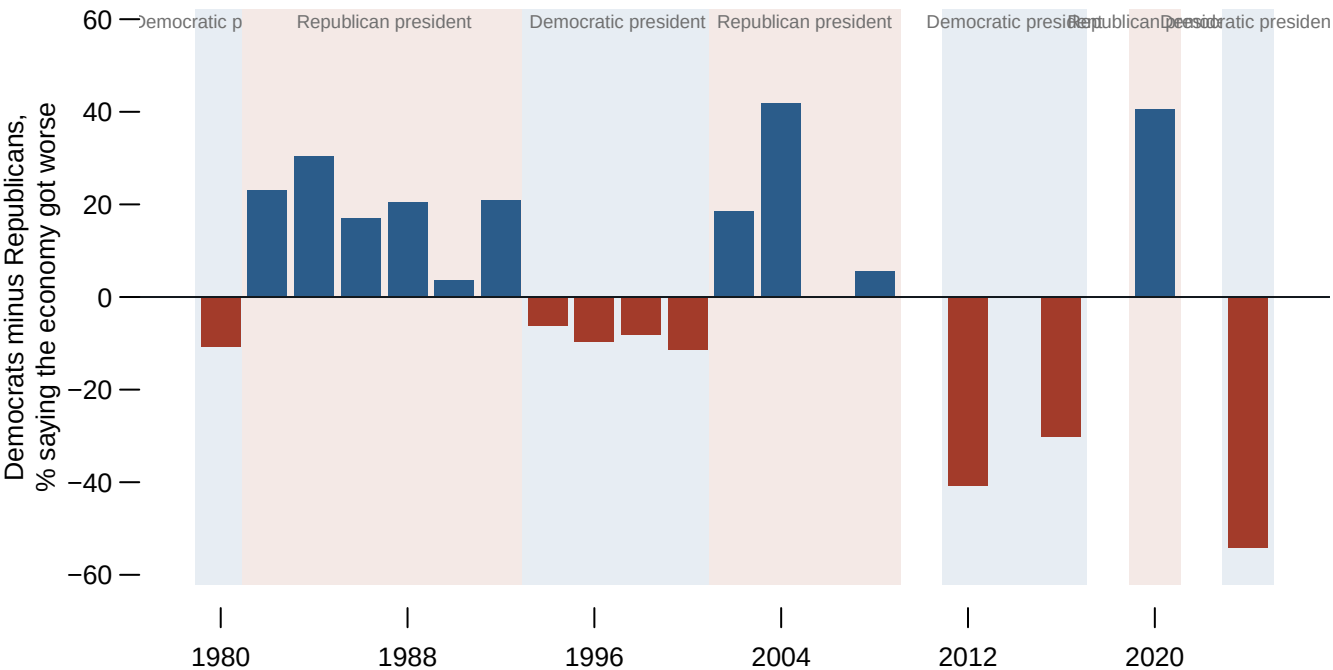


Figure 1. The partisan gap on the national economy, 1980–2024. A bar above the line means Democrats were the more negative group; below it means Republicans were. Hovering gives the two shares the bar is built from, and how many people answered in each group.

The bar points up in every Republican year and down in every Democratic year. That holds in 18 of 18 studies, with no exception in 18 election cycles and six changes of party in the White House.

Year	President	Democrats saying worse	Republicans saying worse	Gap
1980	Democratic	79.1%	89.9%	-10.8 pts
1992	Republican	80.7%	59.8%	20.9 pts
2000	Democratic	10.2%	21.6%	-11.4 pts
2008	Republican	91.7%	86.2%	5.5 pts
2020	Republican	79.9%	39.3%	40.6 pts
2024	Democratic	28.3%	82.5%	-54.2 pts

Notice that the levels move too, not just the gap. In 2020, 79.9% of Democrats said the economy had got worse. Four years later 28.3% did. The same group, the same question, an economy that had grown in both windows, and a 51.6-point swing.

03 The staircase reverses

Split the same question seven ways instead of three and you can see how orderly this is.

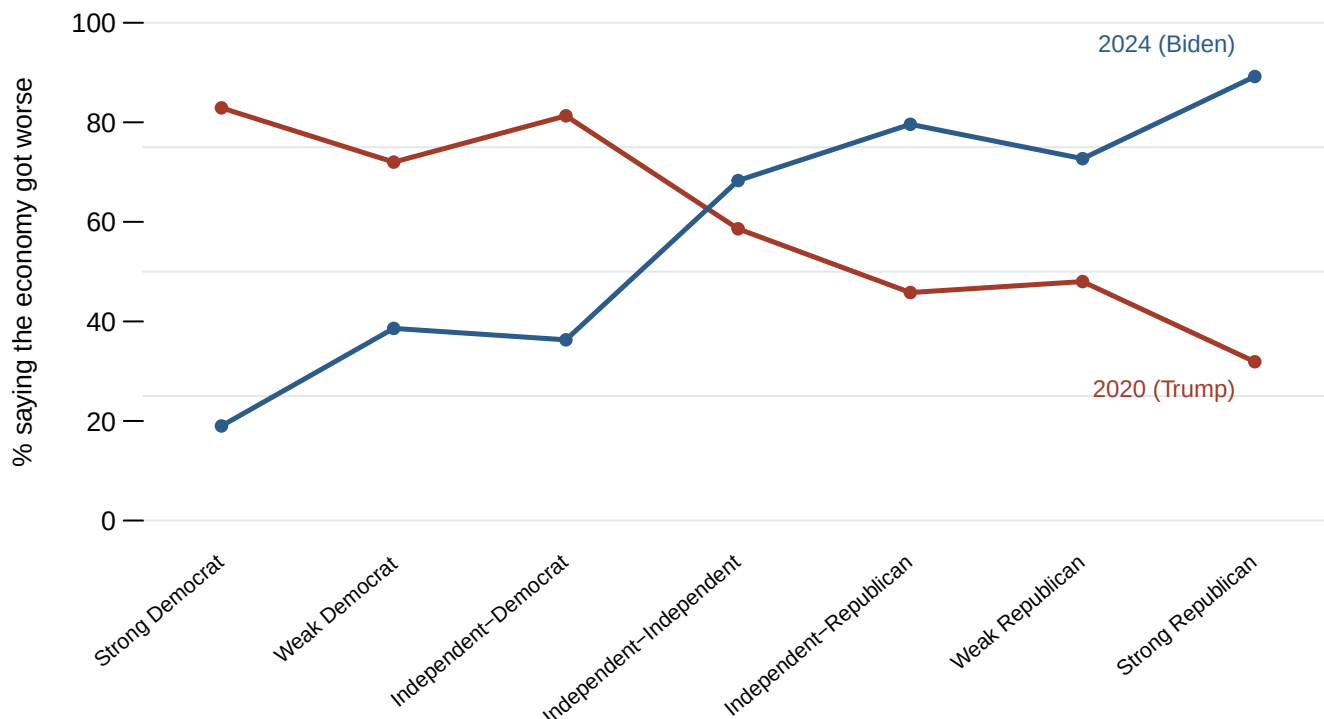


Figure 2. The same question, seven groups, two adjacent studies. In HTML the buttons drop one year so the other can be read on its own. Hovering gives the count behind each point.

In 2020 the line runs downhill: strong Democrats were the most negative group at 82.9% and strong Republicans the least at 31.9%. In 2024 it runs uphill, from 19.0% among strong Democrats to 89.2% among strong Republicans. The order of the seven groups did not scramble. It turned over.

Two details are worth stopping on. People who claimed no party at all sit near the middle in both years, which is what you would expect if partisanship is what moves the line. The leaners sit out near the partisans instead. Those are the people who said “independent” first and named a party only when pressed, and this is the same finding the `party-id` chapter reaches from vote choice, arrived at from a different column.

04 The objection, and the question that answers it

There is a real objection to all of this. Democrats and Republicans are not the same people. They differ in income, age, region and industry, so they may be describing genuinely different economic experiences rather than reporting the same country differently.

The file can answer that, because the same interview asks a second question: are **you** better or worse off financially than you were a year ago. Those two questions differ in a way that matters. The national economy has one true answer for everybody. Household finances have millions of true answers, and Democratic and Republican households really do differ.

So the personal question should carry the bigger partisan gap. It does not.

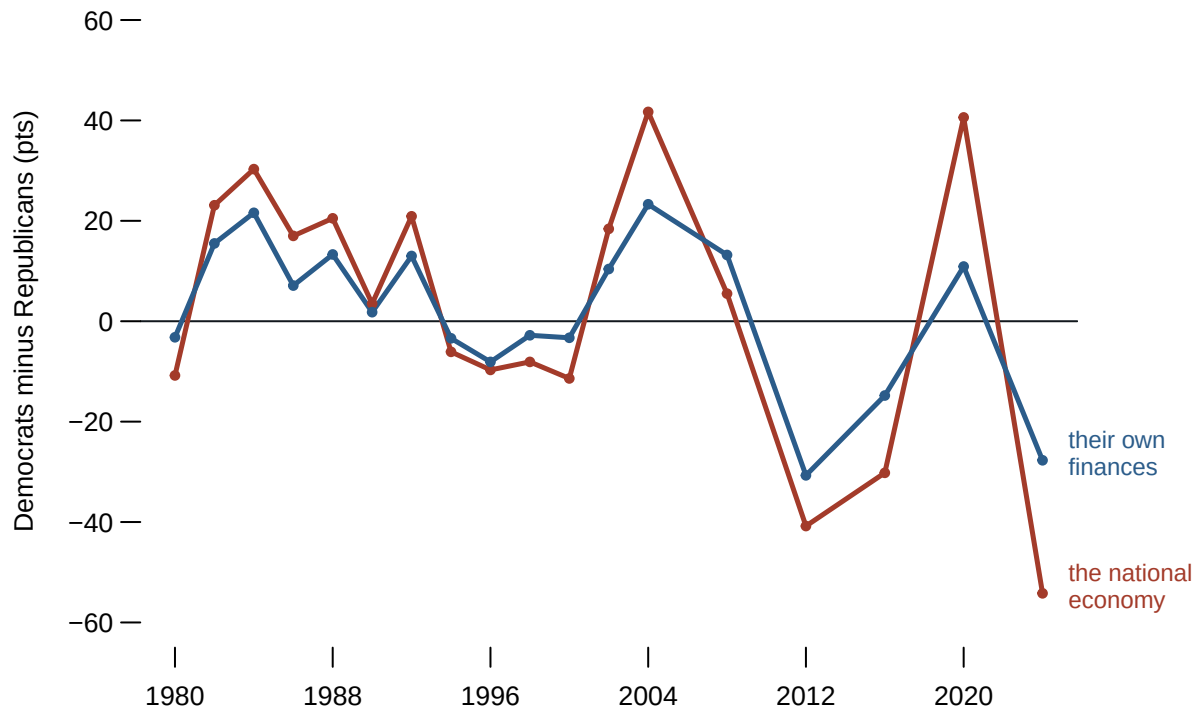


Figure 3. Two subtractions, same people, same interviews. Hovering reports both gaps for a year and says which question is the wider of the two.

Year	The national economy	Their own finances	Wider on
1984	30.3 pts	21.6 pts	the national question
2004	41.7 pts	23.3 pts	the national question
2008	5.5 pts	13.2 pts	their own finances
2016	-30.2 pts	-14.8 pts	the national question
2020	40.6 pts	10.9 pts	the national question
2024	-54.2 pts	-27.7 pts	the national question

The gap on the national economy is wider than the gap on people's own finances in 17 of 18 studies. Both cross zero in the same years, so partisanship reaches the household question too. It just reaches it with about half the force.

That is the finding. The question with one true answer splits the parties further apart than the question with millions of them.

05 Where the gap closes

The two narrowest gaps in the series are 1990 and 2008. Those are the recession of the early 1990s and the financial crisis. In 2008, 91.7% of Democrats and 86.2% of Republicans said the economy had got worse, which leaves very little room for a gap.

2008 is also the one year in Figure 3 where the personal question splits the parties wider than the national one. Both facts have the same cause. When an economy is bad enough, almost everybody says so, and the national question runs out of room before partisanship does.

A bad enough economy is still visible through partisanship. That is a limit on the finding, and it is in the data rather than in a caveat someone added afterwards.

A second prediction. A news organisation wants to report “how Americans feel about the economy” as a single number. **Name one thing that number hides**, and say what you would have to publish beside it before the number became honest.

06 What this chapter cannot tell you

It cannot tell you which party is right. The chapter never compares these answers to what the economy actually did, so nothing here says that one side reads the country correctly and the other does not. Both groups move when the White House changes hands, and the figures show the distance between them rather than the distance from the truth.

It cannot tell you what people believe. A survey records what somebody said to an interviewer. Saying the economy is bad under the other party's president may be a sincere belief, a rough way of saying you dislike the president, or something closer to cheering for a team. Those are different things and this file cannot separate them.

It cannot tell you that nothing real is in these answers. Partisans do differ in where they live and what they do for work, and a policy can genuinely help one group before another. The personal-finance comparison shows that composition is too small to account for the national gap. It does not show that composition is zero.

Nothing here is weighted. VCF0009z is in the file and unused, so every percentage describes the people ANES interviewed rather than the country. Because that caveat is easy to write and hard to trust, every gap was also computed with the weight applied. No sign changes, and the largest difference to any year is 3.9 points.

Finally, the president is not the only thing that changes when the White House changes party. Congress, the news, and the economy itself all move at the same time. The pattern in Figure 1 is as clean as survey evidence gets, and it is still a pattern in eighteen observations rather than an experiment.

07 Sources

- American National Election Studies. *ANES Time Series Cumulative Data File (1948–2024)*, version of 5 February 2026. Ann Arbor, MI and Palo Alto, CA: University of Michigan and Stanford University. <https://electionstudies.org/data-center/anes-time-series-cumulative-data-file/> The file is requested rather than downloaded by a script, and is not redistributed with this book. The `anes` chapter describes what it costs to get.
- ANES. *Time Series Cumulative Data File Codebook*, same release. The wording of VCF0870 and VCF0880, and both code lists, are quoted from it.
- Bartels, Larry M. (2002). "Beyond the Running Tally: Partisan Bias in Political Perceptions." *Political Behavior* 24(2): 117–150.
- Gerber, Alan S. and Gregory A. Huber (2010). "Partisanship, Political Control, and Economic Assessments." *American Journal of Political Science* 54(1): 153–173.
- Bullock, John G., Alan S. Gerber, Seth J. Hill and Gregory A. Huber (2015). "Partisan Bias in Factual Beliefs about Politics." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 10(4): 519–578. On how much of a gap like this survives when respondents are paid for accuracy.

Every number above is recomputed from the file, and checked against the values asserted in `checks.csv`. The table is printed here verbatim.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`gradient.csv`, `national.csv`, `personal.csv`, `weighting.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `national.csv` has gap for every year alongside which party held the White House. Line the two up. How reliably does the sign follow the president?
- `personal.csv` asks people about their own finances rather than the country's. Compare its gaps against `national.csv`. Which question is measuring the economy, and which is measuring the partisanship?
- `gradient.csv` breaks one year out by the full seven-point scale. Read `pct_worse` from one end to the other. Is it a steady slope or a cliff?
- `weighting.csv` reports the gap with and without weights. Look at `difference`. Could weighting ever rescue an answer this partisan?

Check	Value
study years carrying the national economy question	18
years where the sign of the gap matches the president's party	18 of 18
years where the personal-finance gap is smaller than the national one	17 of 18
the only year where it is not	2008
years where the two gaps point the same direction	18 of 18
the two narrowest gaps in the series	1990 and 2008
2020: strong Democrats minus strong Republicans, points	51

Check	Value
2024: the same subtraction, points	-70.2
years where weighting changes the sign of the gap	0
largest difference weighting makes to any gap, points	3.9